Research Proposal Paper Guidelines

Goal: Write a 4 – 6 page APA style paper which explains your research question, why it is important, and proposes a study that you would conduct to investigate this question. This paper will need to include at least 5 peer reviewed sources (i.e., not Wikipedia). These will primarily be for the introduction, but feel free to include more than five if you wish. Note that you will also need to include a title page and references page, neither of which count towards the page limit.

Some basic reminders:

- Double space your paper! (If you give me 6 single spaced pages of content, I probably won't read it….)

- Use a normal font (no wing-dings) – Times New Roman or Calibri are recommended. Use 11 pt or 12 pt font. Anything smaller is font for ants, and anything larger is going to result in me taking off points.

Your paper should at minimum include the following sections, which are detailed below.

Components of the research paper

1) Cover page (APA FORMAT) – You do **NOT** need to include an abstract for this paper.

2) Introduction/Literature Review: Give me the background on your project. Your first paragraph should introduce your topic. Next, provide a few paragraphs exploring previous research. What studies have already been conducted? Are there any inconsistencies in previous work (i.e., do some studies contradict each other?) You'll need to include 5 references in this section.

Your introduction should at minimum be about two pages long. *****Your last paragraph in this section should explain how your research question is related to previous research and should state your hypotheses (i.e., your predictions!) – What do you expect to find?*

3) Method: Your method section will detail how exactly you plan to test your research question. It will consist of the following three sections:

- **3A) Participants:** Who is your sample? (Where are you recruiting them from? How many participants are you planning to recruit? How will they be compensated?)

- **3B) Materials:** What will you be using? Describe any surveys, tests, instruments, etc. in this section
    - **Be sure to provide specific examples!** Where will survey questions come from? What type of scale would you use? What are some examples? *Cite anything that comes from another researcher! (Example: If you plan to use the Big-5 personality inventory, you should cite the authors!)*

- **3C) Procedure:** Give me a step-by-step description of how you plan to conduct your study. You should write in a way that somebody else could easily follow along and reproduce your work.

At minimum, your method section (with all 3 sub sections) should be at least a page.

4) Anticipated Results: What do you expect to find? Specifically what pattern of data would support your hypothesis? (For example, if your hypothesis is that sleep deprivation would lead to worse test performance, tell me that sleep deprived participants would score lower on whatever test you are using compared to well rested individuals) This section should be at least half a page. **YOU DON'T NEED TO REPORT ANY STATISTICS! (YOU AREN'T COLLECTING DATA!)**. Instead, this section should just be your predictions! Think about general patterns of results! What pattern of data would support your predictions?

5) Conclusion: Write at least one paragraph which summarizes your main points. You should also include a take-home message about why your study is important.

6) References: Make sure to include an APA style reference sheet. All references must come from peer reviewed journal articles! If you aren't sure if a reference is suitable for you to use, ask me.

Remember, the cover letter and reference page **DO NOT** count towards the page limit!